The Moderation Movement

How Drinking Culture Is Growing Up in South Africa

An Innovatr deep dive into why people are not drinking less, they are drinking differently.

INNOVATR INSIGHTS

Not Sober. Just Smarter.

South Africans are not abandoning alcohol—they are **reframing it**. Our research shows the shift is not abstinence, but balance. People choose options that preserve clarity, control, and next-day wellbeing.

01

MAINSTREAM SHIFT

Moderation is **mainstream**. It's no longer a niche behavior but a dominant lifestyle choice.

02

INTENTIONAL CHOICES

Alcohol occasions are becoming **intentional**, moving away from mindless default habits.

03

WELLNESS CULTURE

Wellness culture is fundamentally reshaping daily drinking habits and priorities.

04

CATEGORY GROWTH

Low and no-alcohol options are growing rapidly to meet new functional demands.

05

EMOTIONAL VALUE

Emotional outcomes like clarity now matter as much as functional benefits.

Moderation is Now the Norm

Five percent of people enjoyed a non-alcoholic drink in the last week.

5%

...and **95%** of them still drink alcohol.

Moderation is not anti-alcohol — it is an evolution within alcohol culture.

SOURCE: INNOVATR INSIGHTS

From Bravado to Balance

People are *rejecting excess.*

They want the ritual, the taste and the sociability — without the physical or emotional cost.

THE MODERN MINDSET

- **Control** — *participation without consequences*
- **Clarity** — *prioritizing tomorrow over tonight*
- **Intentionality** — *choosing what fits the moment*

> Hangover culture is **out**. High-functioning social life is **in**.

Status Signals Have Changed

Health is the new social flex. The markers of success have shifted from excess to optimization.

72%

Confidence, clarity and control now outrank "how much you can drink."

Globally, people say they prefer flexible or hybrid lifestyles that **support wellbeing** over higher salaries or traditional work expectations. The same mindset shows up in drinking choices.

SOURCE: INNOVATR INSIGHTS

Three Cultural Shifts Behind the Moderation Wave

1

The Wellness Wave

Post-pandemic priorities have matured. People want alignment with their pace of life — not disruption.

SOURCE: INNOVATR

2

Shifting Social Codes

Sobriety and low-alcohol choices no longer feel like “opting out.” They feel socially accepted and increasingly sophisticated.

3

Empowerment Over Restriction

Mindful drinkers are not giving something up — they’re choosing what fits. Moderation signals emotional intelligence, not restraint.

The Three New Drinking Segments

Distinct mindsets driving the future of consumption

46%

Balanced Moderators

Seek connection without losing control. The new cultural mainstream.

SOURCE: INNOVATR

34%

Social Sippers

Still enjoy a buzz but embrace balance and intentional choices.

20%

Conscious Abstainers

Values-led consumers. Comfortable expressing mindful choices openly.

Insight: **The Balanced Moderator is the commercial growth engine.**

It’s Not About Alcohol. It’s About How People Want to Feel.

01

In Control

“ I want to participate without consequences. ”

02

Clear-Headed

“ I want to feel sharp tomorrow. ”

03

Connected

“ I still want the social ritual. ”

04

Recharge Ready

“ I want choices that support my life, not derail it. ”

Insight: **Moderation fits modern emotional needs better than excess.**

Connection First. Buzz Second.

Alcohol is no longer the centrepiece of the moment.

People are shifting the purpose of the occasion from consumption to connection.

THE NEW DRINKING BEHAVIOUR

- More intentional drinking moments
- Shorter sessions, less peak intoxication
- Drinks chosen for mood, not quantity
- Rituals preserved, behaviours refined

Low Alcohol Options Are Not Niche Anymore

Consumers increasingly choose low or zero alcohol options—not to abstain, but to *pace themselves.*

CATEGORY EXPANSION

- **Lagers** — *becoming the default 'spacer' drink*
- **Ciders** — *flavor-first choices for social connection*
- **Spirits** — *premium botanical blends for sophistication*
- **Occasions** — *extending the night without the consequences*

> Low & No options extend the **social moment** without extending the **recovery time.**

PREMIUMISATION THROUGH MODERATION

The New Luxury Is Feeling Good Tomorrow

1. People will pay more for choices that support wellbeing
2. Recovery time has become a key decision driver
3. Moderation signals emotional maturity
4. Clarity and balance feel culturally aspirational

Moderation Is Socially Rewarded

Old stigmas have collapsed. Making mindful choices is now seen as savvy, functional, and socially intelligent.

“You’re driving? Respect.”

RESPONSIBILITY

“Having a low alcohol beer? Smart.”

INTELLIGENCE

“Skipping a round? No pressure.”

AUTONOMY

KEY INSIGHT

The social cost of moderation has disappeared. It is now a signal of **control and high-functioning ambition**.

Different Drinks for Different Energies

The New Moderation Moments

The Warm Up

Light choices that prepare the moment without overwhelming it.

The Middle Ground

Low ABV lagers, crafted 0.0 spirits, easy sippers.

The Wind-Down

Calming, slow, low-impact choices that don't disrupt tomorrow.

The Red Flags of Old-School Drinking Culture

Functional Friction

- Heavy hangovers that ruin the next day
- Harsh flavours that require an "acquired taste"
- Intense ABV spikes causing sudden intoxication
- Feeling out of control physically

Emotional Friction

- Pressure to over-drink to fit in
- Environments that feel unsafe or chaotic
- Fear of social judgement for abstaining
- Unpredictability of the night's outcome

Consumers are actively rejecting **toxicity** and **loss of control** in favor of intentional experiences.

The Moderation Value System

Consumers are rewarding brands that align with their new priorities.

1. Pacing and choice
2. Feel-good flavours
3. Social belonging without pressure
4. Drinks that support the next day
5. Control without compromise

Where Beverage Brands Can Innovate Next

Innovation Territories

Balanced Buzz

Lower ABV brews that preserve sociability, allowing for longer sessions without the loss of control.

Zero-Pressure Social Spirits

0.0 crafted spirits with flavour complexity and grown-up cues that feel sophisticated, not like a compromise.

Recovery-Forward Drinks

Hydrating, vitamin-infused, or balanced functional beverages that actively support tomorrow's wellbeing.

How To Speak to the Moderation Mindset

STRATEGIC PRINCIPLES

Lead with control and clarity

Focus on the functional benefits of staying sharp.

Avoid moralistic or restrictive language

Don't preach. Offer better options, not judgments.

Use emotional cues: calm, confidence, connection

Visuals should reflect relaxed sociability, not isolation.

Celebrate flexible choice

Normalize switching between alcohol and non-alc.

> **Moderation is a lifestyle, not a warning label.**

What This Means for Beer, Cider and Spirits

Category Implications

Beer

- Explosive growth in 0.0 offerings.
- Craft low-ABV innovation.

Cider

- Taste-led propositions.
- Easy-social occasions.
- Flavour-first low options.

Spirits

- Premium non-alcoholic blends.
- Sophisticated mixers.

Insight: Moderation expands category reach, it does not shrink it.

Forty Six Percent of Drinkers Sit in the Moderation Middle

46%

identify as balanced moderators

This is the biggest commercial audience for innovation.

New Packs
Smaller formats and multi-pack variety for flexible pacing.

Occasion Design
Experiences built for connection, not just consumption.

Messaging
Language that celebrates control, clarity, and enjoyment.

SOURCE: INNOVATR

Our Take: Drinking Has Emotionally Evolved

Moderation is not a rejection of alcohol — it is a *redesign of the social ritual.*

CONSUMERS WANT

- **Connection** *without chaos*
- **Enjoyment** *without aftermath*
- **Clarity** *without compromise*

> The brands that thrive will design for balance, not excess.

Build Better Beverage Innovation With Innovatr

OUR INNOVATION CAPABILITIES

- **Test24** concept testing for low/low-ABV and moderation drinks
- **Occasion mapping** to identify untapped moderation moments
- **Pack and emotional design** testing for premium appeal
- **RSA-specific insight** on mood, pace, and choice dynamics

> We map both emotional and behavioural drivers so innovation lands where people actually live.

Book A Conversation With Innovatr

Let us help you innovate for the future of mindful drinking.

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